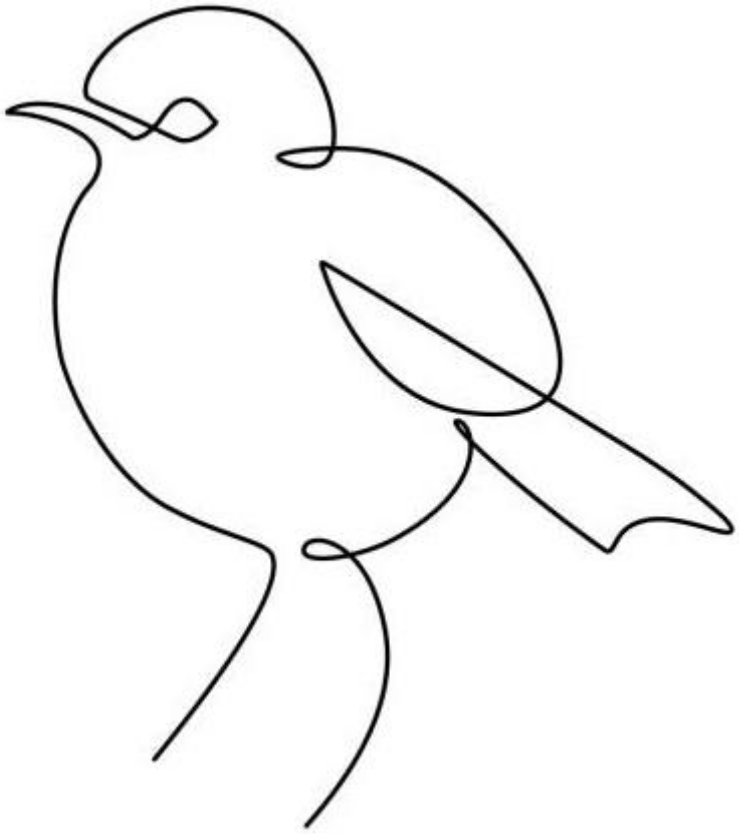
The Bone Sparrow, by Zara Fraillon

Question Booklet



Questions on Context

1. What is the alternative name given to Burma?
2. Roughly how large is the population?
3. In which year was there a military coup?
4. In which year were there mass protests against the military government?
5. In which year did the National League for Democracy (NLD) first get elected?
6. Why was the leader of the NLD at the time?
7. Why weren't the NLD able to govern Burma?
8. What happened to the leader of the NLD?
9. How was the Burmese government structured after the elections in 2015?
10. What religion is practised by as much as 90% of the population of Burma?
11. What religion is practiced by the Rohingya minority group?
12. How have the Rohingya been treated by the government?
13. Are the Rohingya formally recognised as a citizens of Burma?

Chapter 1

Big Question

What do we learn about Subhi and the challenges he faces?

Review Questions

1. What is the name of Subhi's sister? (3)
2. Who says, 'there are some people in the world who can see all the hidden bits and pieces of the universe'? (3)
3. What has happened to the box that Subhi keeps his pictures in? (4)
4. What is the name of Subhi's best friend who lives in Family Tent Four? (5)
5. Who are the 'Jackets'? (5)
6. What does Subhi's mother tell him 'never to look too closely at the food' he is given? (6)
7. Who is Subhi's 'ba'? (8)
8. What animal is 'as old as the universe and as big as this whole country'? (9)

Further Reading

https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/world-asia-pacific-11685977

Chapter 2

Big Question

How is the character of Harvey presented and how is he different from the other Jackets?

Review Questions

1. What toy 'keeps bobbing back up' and 'smiling' in the pool? (18)
2. What is distinctive about the 'face' of the toy? (19)
3. What sort of bird does Subhi discover in the Family Three tent? (21)
4. What is the presence of the bird said to mean? (22)
5. Why is Subhi given a hug? (22)

Further Reading

https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/world-asia-41566561

Chapter 3

Big Question

What do we learn about Jimmie and the challenges she faces?

Review Questions

1. What is the name of Jimmie's pet rat? (25)
2. What did Jimmie's mother place around her neck? (26)
3. What is the name of Jimmie's brother? (26)
4. What did Jimmie find whilst her family was 'packing up the bedroom'? (27)

Further Reading

https://www.theguardian.com/world/2019/aug/04/rohingya-refugee-myanmar-australia-oppression-suffering

Chapter 4

Big Question

What do you learn about the conditions in the refugee camp?

Review Questions

1. Who does Subhi first tell about the sparrow? (31)
2. Who does he tell next? (31)
3. How does Harvey react when Subhi tells him about the sparrow? (31)
4. How many 'pairs of real shoes' are there in the camp? (32)
5. What is Eli's 'business'? (32)
6. Where do you get put 'if you need to be kept more safe than normal'? (34)
7. What sort of people are kept in Beta Compound? (35)
8. What does Eli keep in his pocket to bring him luck? (36)
9. What is the name of the Jacket who catches Subhi delivering a package? (38)

Chapter 5

Big Question

What do we learn about Subhi and Queeny from their encounter with Beaver?

Review Questions

1. Why does Eli say that Beaver hates the refugees in the camp? (41)
2. What is an 'inside package'? (42)
3. What is inside the package that Subhi gets caught with? (44)
4. Who wraps her arms around Subhi after he is hit by Beaver? (44)
5. Who says 'looking back only brings bad things'? (46)
6. What is Subhi's camp number? (48)

Chapter 6

Big Question

What do you learn about Jimmie's relationship with her family?

Review Questions

1. Does Jimmie attend school regularly? (51)
2. What does Jimmie wonder if her dad can remember? (51)
3. What does Jonah say that he will get Jimmie for her birthday? (52)
4. What was Jimmie's mother's favourite tree? (53)
5. Where is the one place Jimmie hasn't explored? (55)
6. What did Jonah teach Jimmie about fences? (57)

Chapter 7

Big Question

What first impressions do Subhi and Jimmie seem to form of each other?

Review Questions

1. Why is Subhi unable to sleep? (59)
2. Why does Subhi rub his eyes after he sees a 'girl just standing' on the other side of the fence? (61)
3. What is she holding? (61)
4. What question does she first ask Subhi? (63)
5. What does the Shakespeare duck say to Subhi at the end of the chapter? (64)

Further Reading

https://www.abc.net.au/news/2021-02-04/what-does-myanmars-military-coup-mean-for-the-rohingya/13114488

Chapter 8

Big Question

What Eli's move to Alpha reveal about how refugees are treated in the camp?

Review Questions

1. Does Subhi tell Harvey that he saw a girl (i.e. Jimmie)? (67)
2. How many different types of dirt does Harvey say there are? (68)
3. What does Eli give to Subhi to eat? (70)
4. What name is printed on the wrappers? (70)
5. Where does one of the Jackets say that Eli is moving to? (72)
6. How long is Eli given to 'get his crap together'? (74)
7. What does Subhi give to Eli just before he leaves? (76)

Chapter 9

Big Question

What do we know about Jimmie so far?

Review Questions

1. What did Jimmie's mum used to talk to? (79)
2. What did Jimmie's mum used to call her? (80)
3. What would a bike help Jimmie to do? (80)

Further Reading

https://www.nationalgeographic.com/culture/people/reference/rohingya-people/

Chapter 10

Big Question

To what extent are the lives of Subhi and Jimmie similar?

Review Questions

1. What did Subhi tell the 'group of three boys' not to do? (84)
2. What has happened to Subhi's shoes? (85)
3. How many nights have passed since Subhi saw Jimmie? (88)
4. Who is 'getting kind of bossy'? (89)
5. How old is Jonah? (90)
6. What does Jimmie initially pull out from her pocket? (91)
7. What does she pull out next? (91)
8. What is 'hanging around' Jimmie's neck? (93)
9. What question does Subhi ask Jimmie at the end of the chapter? (95)

Chapter 11

Big Question

What themes emerge from the opening of the story written by Jimmie's mother?

Review Questions

1. *How is Jimmie related to Anka*? (*97)*
2. *What is stuck to Anka's hair and skin (i.e. in the story)*? (97)
3. *What is the name of the oldest man in the town*? (97)
4. *What is the name of the oldest woman*? (98)
5. *How old is Oto*? (98)
6. *Who is 'destined to see more than most'*? (99)
7. What does Jimmie hand to Subhi at the end of the chapter? (100)

Chapter 12

Big Question

What does the chapter reveal about the importance of storytelling?

Review Questions

1. What did Jonah say to Jimmie's mother about the stories? (103)
2. Did Jimmie join in with Jonah? (103)
3. Jimmie is finally able to sleep deeply for the first time in how many years? (103)

Further Listening

https://thegarretpodcast.com/zana-fraillon/

Chapter 13

Big Question

What similarities are there between the Pebble of Happy and the Bone Sparrow?

Review Questions

1. What does Harvey buy Subhi for his birthday? (105)
2. What does Queeny buy him? (105)
3. Why is the food on the breakfast places 'piled high'? (106)
4. Who calls Subhi over to Family Three? (107)
5. What does 'a few bricks short of a load' mean? (107)
6. What is name of the 'small stone' that Subhi is given for his birthday? (109)
7. What item of food does Subhi save for his mother? (111)

Chapter 14

Big Question

What makes the stories that Subhi and Jimmie tell each other so important?

Review Questions

1. How many stones has Subhi managed to stack on Towers of Rah? (115)
2. Who is the champion? (115)
3. What drink does Jimmie bring for herself and Subhi? (116)
4. What does Subhi draw on Jimmie's arm? (120)
5. *What is 'astonishing' about Anka*? (122)
6. *What causes a 'look of sadness' on Mirka's face*? (123)
7. What does Jimmie give to Subhi so they can communicate with each other? (124)

Further Viewing

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jWEL_y7SRR0

Chapter 15

Big Question

Why is Jimmie so eager to show Subhi where she lives?

Review Questions

1. What does Jimmie release a 'long howl of happiness into the sky'? (129)
2. Why does the howl in her throat turn from 'happy to sad'? (129)
3. What does Jimmie think that Jonah will never notice has gone missing? (129)
4. Where does Jimmie put her mother's book at the end of the chapter? (130)

Chapter 16

Big Question

Why were journalists and photographers banned from visiting the camp?

Review Questions

1. How is Queeny talking to at the beginning of the chapter? (133)
2. What does Queeny pull out of her pocket? (134)
3. Why does Queeny believe it is particularly important? (134)
4. Who taught Subhi to 'read and write and do maths'? (136)
5. Who are the 'Outside kids'? (137)

Chapter 17

Big Question

What are the parallels between the experiences of the Rohingya people and the events of the story?

Review Questions

1. What do we learn has happened to Nasir? (141)
2. Why is Subhi sometimes called 'Aussie Boy'? (142)
3. What is the first image that Jimmie show Subhi on her phone? (143)
4. Who is the man with 'hair as crazy as Jimmie's'? (144)
5. *Who are the only two people who remain after the soldiers visit the town*? (146)
6. How many steps away from the spikey shrub is the weak spot in the fence? (149)
7. What is the letterbox on Jimmie's house made out of? (151)

Chapter 18

Big Question

Why is Queeny becoming increasingly frustrated?

Review Questions

1. What does Subhi find in the sand? (155)
2. What is 'going around the camp'? (155)
3. What does Queeny mean when she says she is 'sick of being invisible'? (157)
4. Why doesn't Jimmie eat octopus? (159)
5. What was the occupation of Subhi's family 'back in Burma'? (160)
6. *Who does Oto have to deliver the Bone Sparrow to*? (163)
7. *What happens straight after the Bone Sparrow falls to the ground*? (164)
8. *How does Oto respond to the situation*? (165)
9. What does Subhi remember Eli telling him about stars? (166)

Further Viewing

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zC_vvRxW-v4

Chapter 19

Big Question

Which factors have contributed to the protest?

Review Questions

1. What has happened to Subhi's mother? (169)
2. What makes the doctor look 'sad and confused'? (169)
3. What do we learn about Saleem? (170)
4. When do the refugees get 'warm toast with butter and honey'? (171)
5. Who looks like 'he's losing bricks'? (172)
6. How many refugees does Beaver say are due to be moved? (174)
7. What does Eli unfold? (176)
8. What is the weather like during the night? (177)

Chapter 20

Big Question

What does Jimmie's father's reaction to the newspaper reveal about wider attitudes towards refugees?

Review Questions

1. Where is Jonah? (181)
2. What picture in the newspaper catches Jimmie's eye? (181)
3. Whose 'warm hand on her shoulder' does Jimmie feel? (182)
4. Does Jimmie feel her dad understands the plight of the refuges? (183)

Chapter 21

Big Question

What does Subhi's experience reveal about the things we tend take for granted?

Review Questions

1. What does Jimmie bring instead of the book and hot chocolate? (185)
2. What does Jimmie say to Subhi when he starts crying? (186)
3. What does Subhi think the coconut smells of? (187)
4. What does Subhi think the strawberries taste of? (187)
5. How does Subhi's stomach feel when he wakes up in the morning? (189)

Chapter 22

Big Question

Why does Jimmie finally feel able to look through her mother's possessions?

Review Questions

1. What time is it when Jimmie gets home? (191)
2. What is the Old Gnome wearing? (191)
3. Who has the 'most beautiful voice'? (191)
4. How does Jimmie fall asleep at the end of the chapter? (192)

Chapter 23

Big Question

What details in the chapter convey the frustration felt by Queeny and Subhi?

Review Questions

1. What does Harvey ask Subhi? (195)
2. What does Subhi draw? (195)
3. Why is Queeny angry? (196)
4. How many men are on hunger strike? (199)
5. What 'treasure' does Subhi find buried in the sand? (200)
6. What does Subhi 'figure' at the end of the chapter? (201)

Chapter 24

Big Question

What is it about her father's new job that Jimmie particularly likes?

Review Questions

1. What present does Jimmie's father give her? (203)
2. What announcement does Jimmie's father make? (204)
3. Is Jimmie pleased with the news? (204)
4. What feeling can't Jimmie shake? (205)

Chapter 25

Big Question

What details suggest that Jimmie is very ill?

Review Questions

1. How many people have their lips sewn shut? (207)
2. What does Subhi 'hope more than anything' for? (208)
3. Who does Subhi tell about the knife? (209)
4. What is the 'burning sweet' that Subhi refers to? (210)
5. What does Subhi pretend to do? (211)
6. What 'doesn't look clean' to Subhi? (212)
7. What hasn't Jimmie noticed? (213)

Chapter 26

Big Question

How do we know that Jimmie is in a desperate situation?

Review Questions

1. What word plays over and over in Jimmie's head? (215)
2. What important device is inside the house? (215)
3. Why is Jimmie unable to retrieve it? (215)
4. What does Jimmie concentrate all her energy on doing? (216)

Chapter 27

Big Question

What aspects of the Jimmie's mother's story does Subhi find so uplifting?

Review Questions

1. What is Subhi worried about at the beginning of the chapter? (219)
2. *What does Anka do as she cooks for the soldiers*? (220)
3. *How do the soldiers thank Anka*? (215)
4. *What does Oto dread*? (221)
5. *What does Oto pass to his son*? (221)
6. What does Subhi see as he looks out into the dark? (222)
7. What is the only thing Subhi can think of at the end of the chapter? (223)

Chapter 28

Big Question

How does Fraillon evoke a threatening atmosphere?

Review Questions

1. Who was responsible for making the searchlights come on? (225)
2. Roughly how many men from Alpha are on hunger strike? (225)
3. What does Subhi liken the Jackets to? (226)
4. What are the Jackets dressed in? (226)
5. What does Harvey give Subhi? (228)
6. What does Subhi do when he reaches the weak spot in the fence? (230)

Chapter 29

Big Question

How is Subhi presented as a caring and resourceful character?

Review Questions

1. Where is Jimmie when Subhi finds her? (233)
2. Who does Subhi phone? (234)
3. What bit does Subhi read that makes Jimmie smile? (236)
4. What does Jonah have in his hand? (237)
5. What do the leaves of the gum tree smell like? (238)
6. What can Subhi smell at the end of the chapter? (239)

Chapter 30

Big Question

How is Beaver presented as a brutal and vengeful character?

Review Questions

1. What is happening to the camp as Subhi returns? (241)
2. Who is Eli running from? (243)
3. What does Eli search for in the ground? (244)
4. What does Beaver do to Eli? (244)
5. Who appears on the scene? (245)

Chapter 31

Big Question

What do we learn about the dangers that refugees face?

Review Questions

1. How many passengers were there in the truck? (249)
2. How many survived the journey? (249)
3. What did Eli tell Subhi about his younger brother? (249)

Further Reading

https://www.theguardian.com/world/2015/may/17/rohingya-burma-refugees-boat-migrants

Chapter 32

Big Question

How does Fraillon evoke a frightening and chaotic scene?

Review Questions

1. Why does Subhi keep watching Eli's hand? (251)
2. What makes Subhi's teeth rattle in his head? (251)
3. Where does Harvey take Subhi instead of Family Three? (253)
4. What question does Harvey ask Subhi at the end of the chapter? (254)

Chapter 33

Big Question

Why doesn't Subhi reveal what he witnessed to Harvey?

Review Questions

1. Who do the jackets blame the riot on? (259)
2. Who does Subhi really want to see? (260)
3. What simple choice does the duck say Subhi has? (260)
4. What does Subhi see that is 'as big as a country and as beautiful as anything'? (262)
5. What is Queeny wrong about? (263)

Chapter 34

Big Question

Why is the poem so special to Subhi?

Review Questions

1. Who is there when Subhi wakes up? (267)
2. Who does Subhi discover conveyed the treasures to him? (267)
3. Who did the treasures originally belong to? (268)
4. What is the last poem in the book about? (269)
5. What was discovered all over the beach after the storm? (270)

Chapter 35

Big Question

In what ways are Subhi and Jimmie like Oto and Anka?

Review Questions

1. Who does Subhi see at the fence? (273)
2. What is Subhi given to wear? (274)
3. What does Jimmie say a sparrow in the house means? (275)
4. What is next to the bed with Subhi wakes? (275)

Chapter 36

Big Question

What is Subhi about to do that causes him so much pain?

Review Questions

1. Who have arrived at the camp? (277)
2. What is the name of the woman who asks Subhi if he wants to go for a 'chat'? (277)
3. *What did Iliya realise*? (278)
4. *What do Iliya's children go on to do*? (278)

Chapter 37

Big Question

Why does Subhi's mother seem to have changed so much?

Review Questions

1. What is Subhi finally able to see 'where the land ends and the sky begins'? (281)
2. What 'burns hot' around Subhi's neck? (283)
3. Why is the duck 'a little worse for wear'? (283)
4. What is left on Subhi pillow? (284)
5. What does Subhi see at the end of the chapter? (284)